

Communication Theory

All About Theories for Communication.

Types of Communication Models – Briefly Explained

in COMMUNICATION / GENERAL, COMMUNICATION MODELS

With the advent of digital technology, the scope and impact of communication have expanded exponentially, making it more crucial than ever to understand the underlying theories and models that govern how we communicate.

Communication Models

Whether verbal, non-verbal, written, or visual, communication shapes our interactions, relationships, and society. Communication models are simplified representations of the overall process that provide a structured way to analyze and understand, highlighting the roles of different elements and their interactions.

Types of Communication Models

Communication models can be classified into three main types. They are

- **Linear Models-** Communication as a one-way process.
- **Interactive Models-** two-way communication added with feedback.
- **Transactional Models-** ongoing and simultaneous communication.

1. Linear Communication Models

Linear models view communication as a one-way process where the sender transmits a message to the receiver without expecting an immediate response. Mass communication, such as television and radio broadcasting or public speeches, falls under this category.

Example- Television News Broadcast

In a television news broadcast, a news anchor (the sender) delivers information about current events. The message is structured news content, transmitted through television signals (the channel). The audience (the receiver) watches the news at home, but there is no immediate feedback or interaction between the news anchor and the viewers.

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A) Aristotle's model

Aristotle's Model of Communication, one of the earliest communication models, emphasizes the speaker's role in delivering a persuasive message. This model, outlined in his work *Rhetoric*, focuses on three key elements:

- 1. Speaker (Who):** Aristotle believed the speaker's credibility (ethos), emotional appeal (pathos), and logical reasoning (logos) determine the message's effectiveness.
- 2. Speech (What):** The content of the message, which should be structured to persuade the audience based on logic, emotion, and trustworthiness.
- 3. Audience (Whom):** The receiver of the message, whose reaction is the ultimate measure of the communication's success.

Example: Imagine a politician giving a speech during an election campaign.

- **Speaker:** The politician, who must establish credibility (ethos) by highlighting their experience and trustworthiness.
- **Speech:** The politician says, "If elected, I will reduce taxes and improve healthcare." Here, they use logos (logic) by presenting clear policies and pathos (emotion) by addressing concerns about the cost of living and healthcare.
- **Audience:** The voters, who respond based on their personal needs, values, and emotions.

For example, a voter worried about rising healthcare costs might be persuaded by the politician's promise.

Aristotle's model is speaker-centered, emphasizing how the effectiveness of communication relies heavily on how well the speaker crafts and delivers their message to influence the audience. This model is especially relevant in public speaking, politics, and advertising, where persuasion is the key goal.

B) Shannon-Weaver Model (1948)

Often referred to as the “mother of all models,” it describes communication as a linear process with five components: sender, encoder, channel, decoder, and receiver. The model also introduced the concept of “noise,” which can interfere with the message at any point in the process.

Example

A person receives a recorded message from their bank regarding a new service. If there is a poor network connection (noise), the message might be unclear or cut off.

C) Laswell's Model (1948)

This model focuses on the effects of communication by asking five questions: Who says, What said, In Which channel, To Whom, and With What effect? It is a must-know topic mentioned in media studies to realize the impact of communication.

Example

A person gets a call from a telemarketer promoting a product. The telemarketer (who) explains the product (what), using the phone (channel) to pitch the offer to the person (to whom), hoping to generate a sale (with what effect).

D) Gerbner's Model of Communication (1956)

Gerbner's Model focuses on the perception and interpretation of messages. It underscores how communication is influenced by the participants' perceptions, attitudes, and experiences. He also introduced the concept of “E” (Event) to explain how reality is perceived and then represented in the communication process.

- **Perceptual Dimension:** How the communicator perceives the event.
- **Interpretive Dimension:** How the message is formulated and understood by the receiver.

Example

A person receives a call from their insurance company after a car accident. The insurance agent's perception of the accident based on the report shapes how they communicate the claim process, while the person interprets the instructions based on their personal experience with the accident.

E) Berlo's SMCR Model (1960)

Berlo's SMCR Model breaks down the communication process into four key components: Source, Message, Channel, and Receiver. This model emphasizes the skills, attitudes, knowledge, and social systems of both participants. It also highlights how the message's encoding and decoding depend on the communicator's abilities in various dimensions.

Example: Classroom Teaching

- **Source:** A teacher explaining a math concept.
- **Message:** The lesson about geometry, is explained through equations and diagrams.
- **Channel:** Visual (board, projector) and auditory (teacher's voice).
- **Receiver:** The students listening and watching the explanation.

2. Interactive Communication Models

Interactive models consider communication as a two-way process where feedback is an essential component. These models recognize that the receiver plays an active role in interpreting and responding to the message, making the communication process more dynamic.

These interactive models emphasize the role of feedback, mutual understanding, and relational dynamics in communication, recognizing the complexity and reciprocal nature of the communication process. The relational dynamics refer to the way communication shapes, influences, and is influenced by the relationship between the communicators.

It implies that communication is about exchanging information, building and maintaining relationships through ongoing interaction.

A) Osgood and Schramm's Circular Model (1954)

This model presents communication as a circular process where each participant can act as a sender and receiver reciprocal, and continuously transmit messages.

He further introduced the idea of a field of experience (backgrounds, knowledge, attitudes, and past experiences), where backgrounds and experiences of both influence the interpretation of the message. Feedback is a central element, emphasising the reciprocal nature of communication.

The field of experience refers to the backgrounds, knowledge, attitudes, and past experiences of both parties. It implies that communication is shaped not only by the message itself but by the shared or differing experiences of those involved in the communication process.

Example: Consider a doctor explaining a medical condition to a patient.

A person calls their doctor to discuss lab results. The doctor explains the results (uses medical terminology), and the person asks follow-up questions (feedback), leading to a continuous loop of explanation and clarification until understanding is reached.

B) Riley and Riley's Sociological Model (1959)

Riley and Riley's model highlights the role of social context in communication. It considers the communicator and receiver as members of social groups, each influencing the communication process. The model emphasizes that communication is not just an individual act but a social one, where social structures and group norms play a crucial role.

Example

A person receives a call from a family member regarding an upcoming family gathering. Both the caller and the receiver are influenced by their roles within the family and the group's expectations, which shape the conversation.

C) Westley and McLean's Model (1957)

This model is particularly relevant for understanding mass communication and the role of intermediaries. It introduces the concept of feedback loops in communication and emphasizes

that communication often involves a third party (such as a journalist or editor) who selects and modifies the message before it reaches the final receiver. The model reflects the complexities of communication in media environments.

- **A (Advocate):** The initiator of the message.
- **B (Intermediary):** The person or entity that processes and interprets the message.
- **C (Consumer):** The final recipient of the message.

Example

A person gets a call from a magazine subscription service. The representative (intermediary) filters and delivers the company's promotional offer (message) to the person (consumer) based on their subscription history.

D) Convergence Model of Communication (Rogers and Kincaid, 1981)

The Convergence Model emphasizes communication as a process where participants gradually come to a mutual understanding. Unlike linear models, this model suggests that communication is not just about transmitting information but about both participants adjusting their thoughts and interpretations until they converge on shared meaning. This model is especially relevant in complex interpersonal or organizational communication.

- Feedback loops allow both parties to exchange messages continuously.
- Focuses on the dynamic process of message interpretation and refinement.
- Ongoing interaction leads to mutual agreement or convergence of meaning.

Example: Team Collaboration in a Workplace

Imagine a team of engineers working on a new product design. At the start, each team member has different ideas and perspectives on how the product should be developed. Through regular meetings and discussions:

- **Initial Communication:** The team members present their design ideas, with some overlap and some differences.

- **Feedback Loops:** As they share feedback, discuss concerns, and clarify misunderstandings, each member adjusts their ideas based on the input from others.
- **Gradual Convergence:** Over time, the team starts to align on a unified design approach as they exchange ideas, clarify priorities, and resolve conflicts.
- **Mutual Understanding:** Eventually, the team converges on a common vision for the product, reaching a shared understanding that integrates the best aspects of each member's contributions.

In this process, communication is continuous and evolving, with feedback and adjustments occurring at each stage, leading to a common understanding, which is the essence of the convergence model. This approach is particularly important in collaborative projects, negotiations, or problem-solving situations where shared meaning is necessary for success.

Related topics : [De Fleur Model of Communication](#)

E) Interactive Model of Communication (Watzlawick, Beavin, and Jackson, 1967)

This model, derived from the authors' work on human communication and behavior, recognizes that communication is a two-way process, with feedback loops playing a vital role. It also emphasizes that all communication has both a content dimension and a relational dimension.

- **Content Dimension:** This refers to the actual information or message being communicated, the literal content of the message.
- **Relational Dimension:** This focuses on the relationship between the communicators and how the message is delivered. It reveals the attitudes, emotions, and dynamics between the people involved in the communication.

The model focuses on how relationships between communicators impact the interpretation and effectiveness of messages.

- Communication involves both [verbal and non-verbal cues](#).

- Acknowledges that the relationship between communicators can influence how messages are understood.
- Miscommunication often arises from relational misunderstandings rather than content alone.

Example: Imagine a manager giving feedback to an employee

- **Content Dimension:** The manager says, “Your report needs revision.” The literal message here is about the need for revisions in the report.
- **Relational Dimension:** The tone and manner of delivery affect the relationship between the manager and employee. If the manager says it with a supportive tone, the employee may feel encouraged to improve the work.
If the manager says it harshly or condescendingly, the employee may feel disrespected or undervalued.

3. Transactional Communication Models

Transactional models view communication as a complex, ongoing process where all parties are simultaneously senders and receivers, continuously influencing each other. This model emphasizes the context of communication, including the physical, social, and cultural environment. Key examples include:

A) Barnlund’s Transactional Model (1970)

Barnlund’s model highlights the multi-layered nature of communication, where both verbal and non-verbal messages are exchanged simultaneously. It stresses that individual experiences, relationships, and social norms influence communication.

Example

A person receives multiple phone calls daily, including one from a client, a friend, and a salesperson. Each interaction is influenced by the person’s relationship with the caller and their past experiences with similar conversations, continuously shaping the flow of communication.

B) Dance’s Helical Model (1967)

This model represents communication as a helix, illustrating that it is a continuous, ever-evolving process influenced by past interactions and experiences.

Example

A person regularly checks in with their supervisor over the phone. With each call, the relationship and communication evolve, building on previous interactions and deepening over time.

Conclusion

Understanding communication models is essential for anyone to navigate the complexities of human interaction. These frameworks provide valuable insights into the dynamics of communication, help become more effective communicators in personal, professional, and societal contexts. As communication continues to evolve in the digital age, these theories and models will remain crucial tools for analyzing and improving the way we connect.



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